

**Tony DeCarlo**

Correctional Officer — Central East Correctional Centre

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## **LETTER TO MY DOCTOR — INSURANCE SUPPORT & TREATMENT**

Last time I was here, I felt you were a little unfair when you told me to just quit my job and move on. I worked my entire adult life to get to where I am, and either you forgot what I do for a living, or I wasn't clear enough — I'm unsure. I have a hard time articulating things without writing them down, so this letter is meant to help with that, and to help fill out my insurance paperwork.

I am a Correctional Officer at the Central East Correctional Centre. I have seen more than the average person will ever see in a lifetime. I have witnessed hangings, deaths, overdoses, stabbings, and violent and horrific beatings. I have been assaulted — physically and verbally — more times than I can count. I have been in situations where entire units of inmates refused to lock up, turning into massive fights with officers.

I have made several attempts to return to work. Every time I try, I struggle the night before and leading up to my shift — sweating, shaking, heart pounding. Most times I have full panic attacks. I don't sleep before a shift. I am scared and traumatized by that building.

The policies and procedures have changed significantly since I started eleven years ago, making the institution considerably more dangerous. The workload has more than doubled. Staff assaults are up over 400%. In previous years, this contributed to my alcoholism and drug abuse. I have done a tremendous amount of work to recover and rebuild my life — but returning to that environment brings all of those feelings back. The darkness creeps in and I want to escape.

I don't know if I can handle another incident — watching another person have their head stomped in, or hearing another alarm go off. I know, right now, that I cannot return to that building without it being complete torture — if I can even get there at all.

I need your help with this. If you are not able to assist me, I would appreciate it if you could point me in the direction of someone who can.

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Prepared by Tony DeCarlo for medical appointment and insurance documentation purposes.